

Taraxacum officinale (Asteraceae)

Dandelion

Known principally as a weed, dandelion has an astonishing range of health benefits. In Western folk medicine, the leaves, which can be eaten in salads, have long been used as a diuretic. They were recommended in the works of Arab physicians in the 11th century, and in an herbal written by the physicians of Myddfai in Wales in the 13th century. The root, which has a shorter history of medicinal use, is good for the liver.



Dandelion's name, which is a corruption of the Latin *dens leonis*, meaning "lion's teeth," derives from the appearance of its flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation

Dandelion grows wild in most parts of the world and is cultivated in Germany and France. It is propagated from seed in spring. The young leaves are picked in spring for tonic salads, and later as a medicine. The root of 2-year-old plants is unearthed in autumn.

Related Species

Pu gong ying (*T. mongolicum*) is used in Chinese herbal medicine to "clear heat" and relieve toxicity, especially of the liver.

Key Constituents

- Sesquiterpene lactones
- Triterpenes
- Polysaccharides

Leaf only:

- Coumarins
- Carotenoids
- Minerals (especially potassium)

Root only:

- Taraxacoside
- Phenolic acids
- Minerals (potassium, calcium)

Key Actions

- Diuretic
- Detoxifying
- Bitter

Research

- **Leaves** Research published in the journal *Planta Medica*, in 1974, confirmed that dandelion leaves are a powerful diuretic, though their exact mode of action is not understood. Many other small-scale studies have confirmed this diuretic, or more accurately, aquaretic effect of dandelion leaf. Aquaretic refers to the fact that many herbal diuretics stimulate just the elimination of water and potassium. As dandelion leaf has very high levels of potassium, it is thought that no net loss of this mineral occurs on taking the leaf.
- **Root** A 2004 laboratory study reported dandelion root had marked anticancer activity. It significantly increased tumor necrosis factor and apoptosis (programmed cell death).

Traditional & Current Uses

- **Diuretic** Dandelion leaf is used as a diuretic and treats high blood pressure by reducing the volume of fluid in the body.
- **Detoxifying remedy** Dandelion root is a key detoxifying herb that gently stimulates the liver and gall bladder's capacity to clear waste products from the body. This action makes it valuable in the many health conditions that involve chronic toxicity, whether this toxicity is linked to inflammation, infection, or dietary or environmental factors. The root is typically taken to treat constipation,

**Dandelion**

A perennial growing to 20 in (50 cm), with ragged basal leaves, hollow stalks, and golden flowers.

Parts Used

Leaves are juiced, eaten raw in salads, or dried for use in herbal preparations.



Dried leaves

Root is harvested after 2 years and is dried or roasted.



Fresh root



Dried root



Fresh leaves

Leaves contain high levels of potassium

Key Preparations & Their Uses

Marigold petals Borage flowers



Tonic salad made with dandelion leaves. Eat regularly for its cleansing benefits.



Tablets have a diuretic effect. Take for fluid retention.



Tincture of root (to make, p. 292). For eczema, take ½ tsp diluted with ½ cup (100 ml) water 3 times a day.



Decoction of root (p. 291). For acne, take ½ cup (75 ml) 3 times a day.



Infusion of leaves (p. 291). For swollen ankles, take 2 cups (500 ml) daily.



Juice made from leaves. For fluid retention, take 1 tbsp 3 times a day.

skin problems, such as eczema, and arthritic conditions, where improved clearance of waste products can reduce local inflammation.

■ **Other uses** Dandelion root is a good prebiotic, supporting the health of the gut flora. It has traditionally been used in the early stages of type 2 diabetes, stimulating insulin release

from the pancreas and supporting stable blood-sugar levels.

Self-help Uses

- **Acne & boils**, p. 305.
- **Constipation**, p. 307.
- **Detoxification for hangover**, p. 309.
- **Fluid retention**, p. 315.
- **Hives**, p. 303.